

The Midnight Visitor

Class 10 CBSE • Footprints Without Feet • Robert Arthur

Detailed Exam-Oriented Solutions

Complete NCERT exercise solutions, character sketches, vocabulary, important quotations, extracts, very-short/short/long answers, value-based and competency-based questions, plus MCQs.

1. Chapter Information

Title	The Midnight Visitor
Author	Robert Arthur
Genre	Mystery / suspense short story
Main Characters	Ausable, Fowler, Max, Henry

2. Character Sketches

Ausable

A secret agent who looks very unlike the glamorous spies Fowler has imagined. He is fat, speaks with an American accent and appears ordinary. Yet he is highly intelligent, calm and quick-thinking. He invents the story of a balcony and then pretends the arriving waiter is the police, causing Max to jump through a window that has no balcony.

Fowler

A young writer who wants to experience the excitement of espionage. At first he is disappointed by Ausable's ordinary appearance and dull hotel room. During the encounter with Max, however, he witnesses Ausable's extraordinary presence of mind and gains a more realistic understanding of a secret agent.

Max

A rival secret agent who enters Ausable's room with a pistol to steal an important report about new missiles. He is alert and threatening but becomes trapped by Ausable's believable inventions. His overconfidence makes him act on false information.

Henry

The waiter who arrives with the drinks Ausable had ordered. His arrival unintentionally provides the sound at the door that Ausable uses to convince Max that the police have arrived.

3. Important Words & Meanings

romantic	imaginative or idealised
passably	just well enough
espionage	spying
sloppy	carelessly dressed
prosaic	ordinary or unexciting
chuckled	laughed quietly
wheezed	spoke with difficulty while breathing noisily

missiles	weapons directed or controlled from a distance
shrilly	in a high, piercing voice
balcony	a platform projecting from a building
presence of mind	ability to remain calm and think clearly in danger

4. Important Quotations / Lines

“Ausable did not fit any description of a secret agent Fowler had ever read.”

Significance: The story challenges the stereotypical image of a glamorous, physically impressive spy.

“You gave me quite a start.”

Significance: Ausable remains calm even though Max has surprised him with a gun.

“That will be the police.”

Significance: This quick lie becomes the central part of Ausable’s plan.

“There were no police.”

Significance: The final revelation exposes Ausable’s clever deception.

“You see, my young friend, there is no balcony.”

Significance: The ending confirms that Ausable invented the balcony story and defeated Max through presence of mind.

5. Complete NCERT Textbook Solutions

A. Read and Find Out — Page 14

Q. How is Ausable different from other secret agents?

Answer: Unlike the glamorous secret agents Fowler has read about, Ausable is fat, ordinary-looking and has an American accent. He does not appear athletic or adventurous, but he possesses exceptional intelligence and presence of mind.

Q. Who is Fowler and what is his first authentic thrill of the day?

Answer: Fowler is a young writer who wants to experience the excitement of espionage. His first authentic thrill comes when he enters Ausable’s room and sees Max standing there with an automatic pistol.

B. Read and Find Out — Page 16

Q. How has Max got in?

Answer: Max has entered Ausable’s room using a passkey.

Q. How does Ausable say he got in?

Answer: Ausable falsely says that Max entered through a balcony attached to the room. There is actually no balcony.

C. Think About It

Q. What do secret agents in books and films look like, and how is Ausable different?

Answer: Fictional spies are often shown as stylish, physically fit, handsome and adventurous. Ausable is the opposite: he is fat, ordinary-looking and appears unremarkable. The story shows that intelligence and presence of mind matter more than appearance.

Q. How does Ausable make Max believe there is a balcony?

Answer: He describes the balcony confidently and casually, even complaining that someone has entered through it before. His detailed, natural-sounding explanation makes Max accept the

information without checking it.

Q. When did Ausable think up his plan?

Answer: He most likely invented the plan after seeing Max and realising that the balcony story could be useful. The later arrival of the waiter gives him another opportunity to claim that the police have arrived. His success shows his ability to adapt instantly.

D. Talk About It — Model Answers

Q. Give an example of presence of mind.

Answer: Presence of mind means staying calm and taking sensible action during danger. For example, if a small fire starts in a kitchen, a person should immediately warn others, switch off the gas or electricity if safe, use an appropriate extinguisher and call emergency services instead of panicking.

Q. What would you do if a small fire starts in your kitchen?

Answer: I would alert everyone, move away from danger, switch off the gas/electric supply only if it is safe, use the correct extinguisher for the type of fire, and call emergency services. I would never throw water on an electrical or oil fire.

Q. What would you do if a child starts to choke?

Answer: I would seek immediate emergency help and use appropriate first-aid choking procedures if trained. I would not blindly put fingers into the child's mouth.

Q. What would you do if an electrical appliance sparks?

Answer: I would stay away from the appliance, switch off the power from a safe point, keep others away and call a qualified electrician if needed.

Q. What would you do after a bicycle knocks down a pedestrian?

Answer: I would ensure immediate safety, call for medical assistance if necessary, help the injured person without moving them unnecessarily, and provide accurate information to authorities.

Q. What would you do if heavy rain continues for more than twenty-four hours?

Answer: I would follow local safety advisories, avoid flooded roads, keep essential supplies ready and move to a safer location if authorities advise evacuation.

Q. What would you do if a family member does not return home at the expected time?

Answer: I would contact them, check likely locations, inform trusted relatives and, if there is genuine concern for their safety, contact the appropriate authorities rather than waiting passively.

6. Extract-Based Questions

“Ausable did not fit any description of a secret agent Fowler had ever read.”

1. Why was Fowler disappointed?

Answer: Fowler expected an exciting, glamorous spy.

2. How did Ausable look?

Answer: He was fat and ordinary-looking.

3. What quality does the story show is more important than appearance?

Answer: Intelligence and presence of mind.

4. Who changes his view during the story?

Answer: Fowler.

“That will be the police,” he said.

1. Who says this?

Answer: Ausable.

2. Is it true?

Answer: No.

3. Why does Ausable say it?

Answer: To make Max believe that the police are coming.

4. What effect does it have on Max?

Answer: Max becomes frightened and tries to escape through the supposed balcony.

“There were no police.”

1. Who says this?

Answer: Ausable.

2. Who was actually at the door?

Answer: Henry, the waiter.

3. What does this reveal about Ausable?

Answer: He is highly resourceful and has controlled the situation through deception.

4. Why is the ending surprising?

Answer: The supposed police were only a waiter, and the balcony never existed.

7. Very Short Answer Questions

Q. Who is Ausable?

Answer: A secret agent.

Q. Who is Fowler?

Answer: A young writer.

Q. Who is Max?

Answer: A rival secret agent.

Q. What does Max want?

Answer: A report about new missiles.

Q. How does Max enter the room?

Answer: With a passkey.

Q. What false feature does Ausable describe?

Answer: A balcony.

Q. Who knocks at the door?

Answer: Henry, the waiter.

Q. Are there police outside?

Answer: No.

Q. What happens to Max?

Answer: He falls after jumping from the window, believing there is a balcony.

Q. What quality saves Ausable?

Answer: Presence of mind.

8. Short Answer Questions

Q. Why was Fowler disappointed on meeting Ausable?

Answer: Fowler expected a glamorous, adventurous secret agent. Ausable was fat, ordinary-looking and staying in a small, dull hotel room. He did not match Fowler's romantic image of espionage.

Q. How does Ausable defeat Max without using force?

Answer: He invents a balcony and later claims that the police are at the door. Max believes both lies and, in panic, jumps out of the window expecting to land on the balcony.

Q. Why is the balcony important to the story?

Answer: The balcony is entirely imaginary, but Ausable's confident description makes Max believe it exists. This false detail becomes the means by which Max is tricked into jumping from the window.

Q. What does Fowler learn from the incident?

Answer: He learns that a secret agent need not look glamorous or perform dramatic physical stunts. Intelligence, calmness and quick thinking can be much more important.

Q. Why does Max's confidence become a weakness?

Answer: Max believes he understands the situation and trusts the information Ausable gives him. His haste and failure to verify the balcony make him vulnerable to Ausable's deception.

9. Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe Ausable's presence of mind in the story.

Answer: Ausable remains remarkably calm after finding Max in his room with a pistol. Instead of panicking, he immediately invents the existence of a balcony and explains it naturally. Later, when a knock is heard, he claims that the police have arrived. Max, frightened by the possibility of being caught, decides to escape through the window. He jumps expecting a balcony but falls because none exists. Ausable therefore defeats a dangerous armed rival through calm thinking, confidence and adaptability.

Q. How does the story challenge the conventional image of a secret agent?

Answer: Fowler expects a secret agent to be handsome, physically fit, stylish and involved in exciting action. Ausable is fat, ordinary-looking and has an unremarkable hotel room. Yet he proves far more effective than the stereotypical spy because he can remain calm and manipulate a dangerous situation with words. The story shows that intelligence and presence of mind are more important than appearance.

Q. Explain the role of deception in the story.

Answer: Deception is central to Ausable's survival. He deceives Max by inventing a balcony and then by pretending that the police have arrived. Max also uses deception when he enters with a passkey

and tries to steal the report. The difference is that Ausable uses deception defensively to protect himself and the report, while Max uses it to commit a crime.

10. Value-Based Questions

Q. What can students learn from Ausable's behaviour under pressure?

Answer: They can learn to stay calm, observe the situation, think before acting and use available information intelligently rather than reacting impulsively.

Q. Why is mental preparedness important?

Answer: Unexpected situations require quick decisions. A calm and prepared mind can identify options and reduce panic, as Ausable demonstrates.

Q. How can overconfidence create danger?

Answer: Max assumes his understanding is correct and does not verify the balcony. His overconfidence prevents him from questioning information and leads directly to his downfall.

11. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why does Ausable speak with an American accent?

Answer: He has lived in Paris for many years but has retained the American accent he brought from Boston.

Q. Why is Fowler important to the story?

Answer: Fowler provides the reader's perspective. His expectations and reactions highlight how different Ausable is from the stereotypical secret agent.

Q. Why does Max wait in the room?

Answer: He wants to obtain the important report about new missiles that Ausable is expecting.

Q. What makes Ausable's balcony story believable?

Answer: He gives specific details, behaves naturally and speaks as though the balcony is a familiar nuisance.

Q. Why does Max jump?

Answer: He believes the police are coming and thinks the balcony offers him a safe escape route.

12. CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

Q. Competency-based: A person in danger begins to panic. What practical lesson can be drawn from Ausable?

Answer: Panic can reduce the ability to assess options. Remaining calm, observing carefully and thinking step by step can create solutions even in difficult circumstances.

Q. Case-based: Max has a weapon, but Ausable controls the situation. What does this show?

Answer: Physical power does not automatically guarantee control. Intelligence, communication and psychological awareness can change the balance of a situation.

Q. Analytical: 'Ausable wins because he controls the story, not because he controls the room.' Explain.

Answer: Ausable cannot physically overpower Max. Instead, he controls Max's understanding of the situation by creating believable false information. Max acts according to that false version and defeats himself.

13. MCQs

1. Ausable is different from stereotypical spies because he is:

- A. very young B. fat and ordinary-looking C. silent D. uneducated
2. Fowler is a:
- A. policeman B. writer C. waiter D. scientist
3. Max carries a:
- A. knife B. rifle C. small automatic pistol D. sword
4. Max wants:
- A. money B. the missile report C. a passport D. a key
5. Max enters using a:
- A. ladder B. balcony C. passkey D. tunnel
6. The balcony is:
- A. real B. imaginary C. under repair D. hidden
7. Who comes to the door?
- A. police B. Fowler C. Henry D. Max
8. Ausable's strongest quality is:
- A. physical strength B. presence of mind C. wealth D. speed
9. Max jumps because he believes:
- A. a balcony is below B. Fowler is armed C. the report is gone D. Henry is a spy
10. The story is mainly about:
- A. romance B. cleverness under pressure C. travel D. science

MCQ Answer Key

1-B, 2-B, 3-C, 4-B, 5-C, 6-B, 7-C, 8-B, 9-A, 10-B

14. Teacher's Note on Answer Writing

2-3 marks: Answer directly and include the key reason/event.

5-6 marks: Use a clear opening, 3-4 developed points and a concluding inference.

Extracts: Identify context/speaker first, then answer precisely.